IIT Delhi has also revamped its curriculum to help students tackle study pressure effectively.

All the IITs also have wellness centres now and some of them are taking innovative steps for student welfare. Mittal says early detection of symptoms is the key. "At IIT Delhi, we have a customised student and faculty mentorship programme. Six senior students take care of 10-20 juniors. The seniors identify the juniors who are suffering or facing problems and take them to a faculty member who then guides them on how to navigate the challenging systems of education," he says. In hostels, students regularly host dinners for faculty members where both sides engage in freewheeling conversations about non-academic issues.

At IIT Guwahati, Professor Bithiah Grace Jaganathan, associate dean, students' affairs, says the availability of counsellors in the counselling centre has been extended and mandatory interactions are held with first-year students to familiarise them with the centre and counselling services. Counsellors work in collaboration with other clubs within the institute to spread awareness regarding mental health conditions. Institute- and hostel-level welfare activities are regularly held to help students identify stress factors and how to cope with them. The centre also conducts Critical Incident Stress Debriefing immediately after every suicide for hostel mates and friends.

Students and mental health experts, however, allege that most of these student welfare cells are not functioning adequately. Others say that even at full strength, the manpower is not enough to handle the increased student load. Not everyone agrees, though. Pointing out that a faculty advisor is assigned for every 20 students, an IIT Madras student says that these advisors, if mindful of students' grades, attendance and social behaviour, can avert suicides by helping them clear backlogs and ease academic pressure.

Everyone agrees that the authorities at the IITs need to take more proactive steps. In the first week of May, IIT Madras launched a comprehensive wellness survey, involving one-to-one conversations between students and more than 30 trained counsellors from an independent agency. Of the 35 students who died by suicide across IITs since 2018, 12 were from IIT Madras, the highest among all IITs. "IIT Madras is committed to working towards ensuring the wellness of all on her campus. The independent wellness survey is one of the important steps taken in this direction," says its director V. Kamakoti. Dr Shetty believes there is scope to do more. "The IITs spend crores in holding tech fests every year. Some amount of money should be spent on frequent mental health camps," he says.

Most mental health experts suggest that IITs should have longer induction schedules before regular courses begin so that students from diverse backgrounds get enough time to adjust to campus life. The management should also organise extra classes for students who have learning gaps. The pace of the semesters should also be slowed down. To prevent caste conflicts, mandatory sensitisation programmes must be introduced.



"IF THERE IS A COMPLAINT THAT RESERVED CATEGORY **STUDENTS ARE SUFFERING MORE, WE CAN'T OVERLOOK THE MATTER.** WE MUST RECTIFY IT"

PROF. ADITYA MITTAL
Dean of Students Affairs, IIT Delhi

4.5
PER CENT

RISE IN OVERALL STUDENT SUICIDES IN 2021, ACCORDING TO NATIONAL CRIME RECORDS BUREAU DATA

NOT A PATTERN?

While the recent spate of suicides has triggered a debate on how the IITs handle the mental health of their students, several observers and insiders assert that there is nothing that can be identified as a trend in these suicides. "These incidents are unfortunate, and we are highly affected by these distressing deaths of students," says Mittal. "However, there is no particular pattern related to the triggers leading to such deaths." Jaganathan, though, discerns a few. "The victims are mostly males," she says. "Family issues are significant contributors to the stress level of students. Academic stress and psychiatric conditions are all commonly observed."

Others think student suicides are an unfortunate reality and IITs are no exception. "Some students fail to cope with the pulls and pressures of life and take drastic steps. They could be from any institute. It's not fair to single out IITs just because these are the country's best," says a professor from IIT Kharagpur. He has a point. According to the NCRB's Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India report, student suicides rose by 32 per cent between 2017 and 2021. Among the 13,000 students who died in 2021, only seven were IITians.

But that is hardly any consolation. As these bright young minds struggle with multiple issues affecting their mental health, the need of the hour is an academic environment that allows them to blossom in the right direction. When students start to slack and look for support, they need to know which door to knock on for help. ■